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1906, Land Colonisation Bill

Arjan Singh and Jai Kaur had three sons. All doggedly followed in their parents' illustrious footsteps. There was Kishan Singh (1878–1951), who was Bhagat Singh's father, and then there were his two uncles, Ajit Singh (1881–1947) and Swaran Singh (1887–1910). All three of them were born in Khatkar Kalan on the Indian side of Punjab. All three met with an unsung and uncelebrated death. Kishan Singh had originally been named 'Gobind Singh' and was called by the nick-name of 'Gobinda' until he underwent Sikh baptism at the age of eight at a Holi celebration in 1886 and was given the name Kishan Singh. In 1906, as an ardent follower of the Arya Samaj, he formed the Bharat Mata Society ('Hail Mother Country' Society) together with his two brothers. In 1907, the year that Bhagat Singh was born, he opposed the Bari Doab Canal Rates and the Land Colonisation Bill. [1] That is when he was arrested and suffered life-long exile as explained below.

It is often forgotten that India had two freedom movements. One consisted of the demands of urban Indian politicians; the other of indigenous political organizations [2] living off the land (as we have already seen in this chapter so far). The latter group has been much neglected in accounts of India's quest for freedom from foreign rule. Yet, it was a powerful movement, as it was most affected by the Punjab Alienation of Land Act 1900, as previously noted. This was the first paternal legislation passed by the British. It divested the farming community of zamindars, of their right to sell or mortgage their land unless approved by the district officer. This left them justifiably aggrieved. An approval for land alienation would only be granted by a district officer if the recipient of the land could